NewsBank inc.

California to ban ultra processed foods from school meals - The legislation is seen as a move by California's Democrats to outflank the Trump administration's efforts to reform American health

October 14, 2025 | Daily Telegraph, The/The Sunday Telegraph: Web Edition Articles (London, England)
Author: Maeve Cullinan, Global Health Security Reporter | Section: Global health | 519 Words
OpenURL Link

California will become the first state in the US to ban schools from serving children ultra-processed foods.

New legislation signed by Gavin Newsom, California's Governor, last week, will formally define ultra-processed foods (UPFs) for the first time and requires all schools to have phased them out by 2035.

The "Real Food, Healthy Kids Act" will target foods that are high in saturated fat, added sugar, or sodium, and containing at least one specified additive, such as artificial dyes, flavours, sweeteners, emulsifiers, or thickening agents.

California's Department of Public Health must finalise the definition by 2028, including identifying any exemptions and designating categories such as "ultra-processed foods of concern" and "restricted school foods".

The finalised guidance will then be distributed to schools, with the process of phasing out the foods starting in 2029.

On average, American children get nearly two-thirds of their daily intake of calories from "junk" foods, according to a recent report from the US Centres for Disease Control (CDC). They have been linked to increased health risks, including cardiovascular conditions, diabetes, and some cancers.

The bill was lauded by nutritionists and health professionals and is seen as a move by California's Democrats to outflank the Trump administration's efforts to reform American health.

US Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr's 'Make America Healthy Again' commission had promised to take action on ultra-processed foods by August of this year.

But its latest report, released last month, was criticised for being exceedingly vague and offering no concrete policy recommendations on how to break the country's addiction to junk food.

"California has never waited for Washington or anyone else to lead on kids' health – we've been out front for years, removing harmful additives and improving school nutrition," Governor Newsom said in a statement.

Jesse Gabriel, the Democrat who introduced the bill, told a press conference: "While folks in DC are commissioning reports and debating hypotheticals, California is leading with decisive action.

"Or to put it more bluntly, here in California, we are actually doing the work to protect our kids' health, and we've been doing it since well before anyone had ever heard of the MAHA movement," he added.

Last year, California also became the first state to ban six of the most common synthetic food dyes from school meals, which had been linked to neurological problems in some children. The law will come into effect from 2027.

Among the banned products are those that contain Red 40 – a dye found in products like Doritos, Gatorade, and Skittles – which has been found to make children and teenagers more hyperactive or irritable in some studies.

Governor Newsom's quest to make school food healthier has been likened to Jamie Oliver's efforts to tackle the

same issue through a reality TV programme called Jamie’s American Food Revolution.

Protect yourself and your family by learning more about Global Health Security

© Telegraph Media Group Holdings Limited 2025

- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Cullinan, M. (2025, October 14). California to ban ultra processed foods from school meals - The legislation is seen as a move by California’s Democrats to outflank the Trump administration’s efforts to reform American health. *Daily Telegraph, The/The Sunday Telegraph: Web Edition Articles (London, England)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/1A3BA29DA34B2BE8.